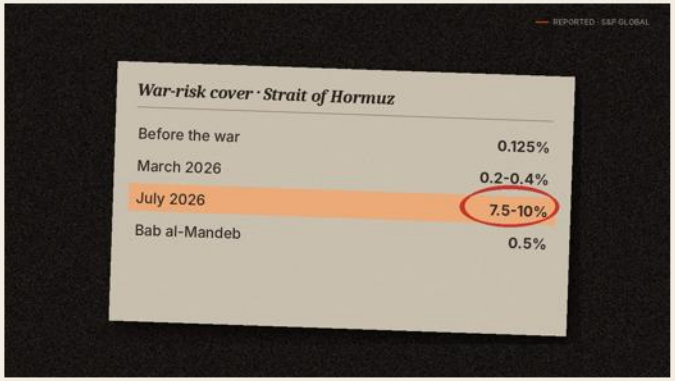
INV-007 · The Prisoners of Hormuz

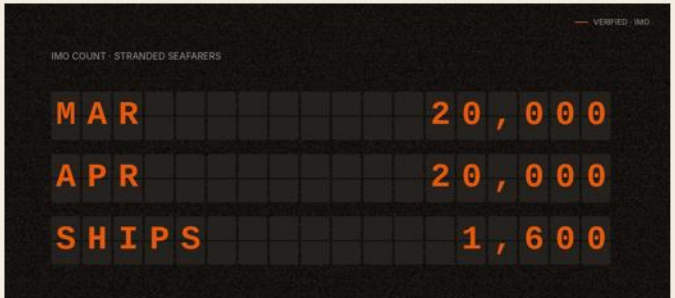
Storyboard v1 + picture playbook · new 'ledger' look from the Round Two reference

- Script v1: 106 paragraphs · 3151 words · about 24 min of voice (can grow to ~30)
- Mix by narration time: graphics 59% · video 27% · photos 15% (target 50 / 30 / 20)
- Every video clip and photo matches the line being spoken. If no match is found, the shot becomes a graphic.
- No 'Illustration' label on screen (YouTube's synthetic-content box is still ticked at upload).
- Photos and clips in this storyboard are first picks from Pixabay; final clips are fetched per line before render.
- Pages 2-3: the playbook (reference frame vs our version). Then every paragraph in order.

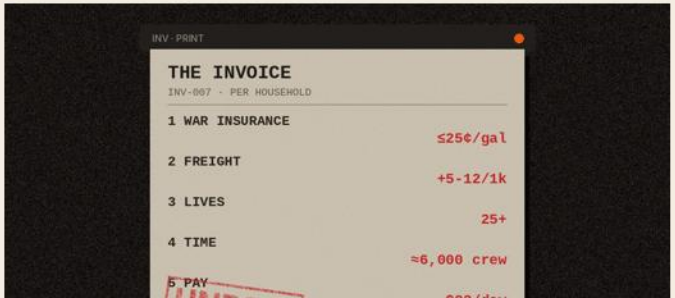












N Ledger number card
reference at 0:00





Hold max 6 s, then cut

L Toned footage + orange glow + paper label
reference at 0:17

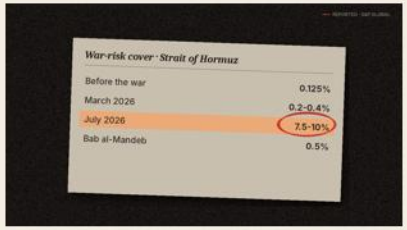




Only clips that match the line

D Document, key line circled
reference at 0:39





Use for reports, rates, contracts

T Typed paper card + rubber stamp
reference at 0:58





Stamp = the confidence tag

B Split-flap board
reference at 1:22





Flips in, digits roll

K Cut-paper figures + paper tags
reference at 1:38





Faceless; never real people

M Navy globe / map, orange arcs, pins
reference at 2:29



→



Arcs draw on; pins drop

P Part card, giant faded number
reference at 3:15



→



Fade through black + riser

R Receipt printer + stamps
reference at 4:48



→



Prints line by line

W Mini-chart tiles
reference at 5:52



→



Lines draw left to right

X Folder + index cards
reference at 6:46



→



Cards slide in one by one

E Particle logo end card
reference at 8:53



→



Particles assemble



The Gulf, north of Qatar. The fifth of November, 2026. A tanker called Velos Sapphire is hit. One member of her crew does not go home.

PHOTO **CO-01** SHADOW

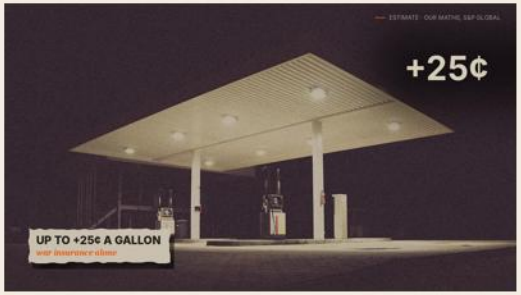
Tanker at night on dark water, slow push; cut to black on 'go home'. + L label 'NORTH OF QATAR · 5 NOV 2026'



He was the twenty-fifth. That's how many seafarers the IMO, the United Nations shipping agency, has counted dead around the Strait of Hormuz since this war began in February.

GRAPHIC **CO-02**

N ledger card: 25 types in, orange serif line 'seafarers killed since 28 Feb 2026'; tag top-right VERIFIED · IMO



And the bill for keeping ships trapped behind that strait reaches you. By our estimate, up to twenty-five cents on a gallon of petrol, from war insurance alone.

VIDEO **CO-03** COLOUR · INTENSE

Empty petrol station at night (toned) + corner '+25¢' + label 'Up to +25¢ a gallon'; 2 s receipt flash



Behind that number are people. By one count in late October, about six thousand seafarers on up to four hundred ships. Many have not stepped ashore since July.

VIDEO **CO-04** COLOUR · INTENSE

Aerial of many ships at anchor off a coast (toned, orange glow spot on one ship) + L 'ABOUT 6,000 CREW · UP TO 400 SHIPS'



Some of these numbers are counts, not certainties. In the spring the IMO said twenty thousand. A port operator now says six thousand. Nobody has a full list. We'll show you who says what.

GRAPHIC **CO-05**

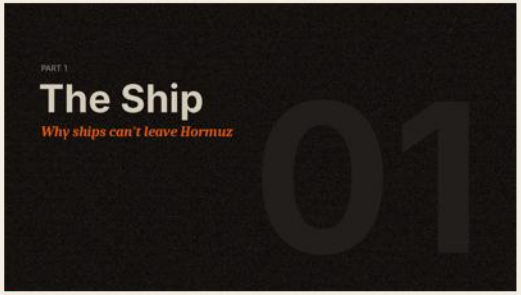
T two typed paper cards side by side: 'IMO · 20,000 · MAR 2026' and 'DP WORLD · 6,000 · OCT 2026'; stamp REPORTED on the second



By the end, you'll see every line on this bill, including the ones that aren't money. We'll go aboard the ships, read the contract that keeps the crews there, count who has been lost, look at the last time this happened, follow the money, and land on your table.

GRAPHIC **CO-06**

X folder opens: six index cards fan out (THE SHIP … YOUR TABLE)



Part one. The ship.

GRAPHIC **P1-01**

P part card: giant faded 01, 'The Ship', orange sub 'Why ships can't leave Hormuz'



Before this war, about eighty-five ships a day crossed the Strait of Hormuz. They carried around a fifth of the world's seaborne oil, and a fifth of its liquefied gas.

GRAPHIC **P1-02**

M navy map of the strait, two orange lanes, B split-flap counter '85 / DAY'



Then, on the twenty-eighth of February 2026, the strikes on Iran began. Within days, insurers pulled the war cover that protects a ship's crew and cargo. The strait was still open on paper. In practice, it shut.

VIDEO **P1-03** COLOUR · CALM

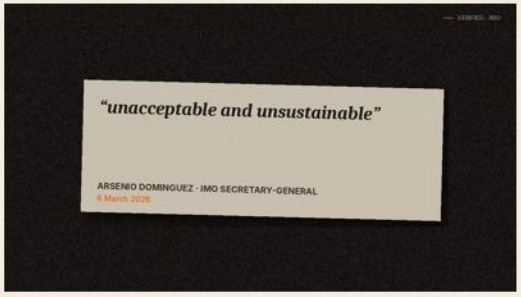
Tanker at anchor, still water, no movement (toned) + L 'OPEN ON PAPER · SHUT IN PRACTICE'



The first week set the pattern. On the first of March, two ships were hit and three people were killed. On the sixth, a tug called Mussafah 2 went to help a burning ship and sank. Four of her crew died.

VIDEO **P1-03b** SHADOW

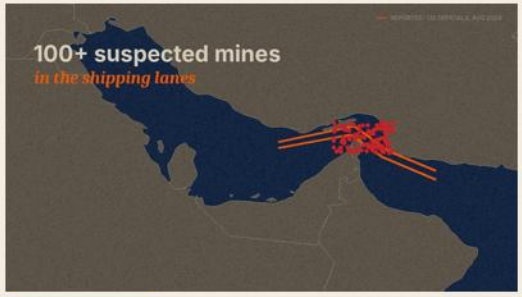
Tugboat at sea (toned), torn-paper wipe to M pin 'MUSSAFAH 2 · 6 MAR'



The IMO's Secretary-General called it unacceptable and unsustainable. At that point, his agency counted about twenty thousand seafarers stranded inside the Gulf.

GRAPHIC **P1-03c**

T typed quote card, stamp 'IMO · 6 MAR 2026'



Then came the mines. By late August, the US said it had found more than a hundred suspected mines in the shipping lanes. So a captain inside the Gulf faced a simple choice. Stay put, or sail through water nobody could promise was clear.

GRAPHIC **P1-04**

M strait map, 100+ red pins drop; label 'SUSPECTED MINES'



Most stayed. In April, the head of the Emirates' state oil company said two hundred and thirty loaded tankers were waiting inside the Gulf. In May, Saudi Aramco's chief put it at more than six hundred ships inside, and two hundred and forty outside.

VIDEO **P1-05** COLOUR · INTENSE

Row of tankers waiting at anchor, slow pan + B split-flap '230 → 600+'



A ship is a small town that can't leave. On the cargo ship that caught fire in the Gulf of Oman on the eighth of November, there were twenty-two people. A kitchen, a few cabins, an engine that must keep turning.

VIDEO **P1-06** COLOUR · INTENSE

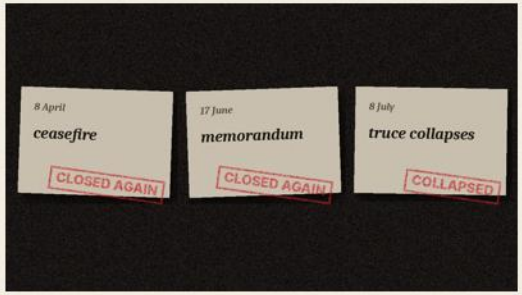
Inside a ship: galley / narrow corridor, warm light, no faces + L '22 CREW'



Every day a ship waits, it eats food, drinks water and burns fuel that has to come from somewhere. By late April, the IMO warned those supplies on the stranded ships were expected to run short.

PHOTO **P1-07** COLOUR

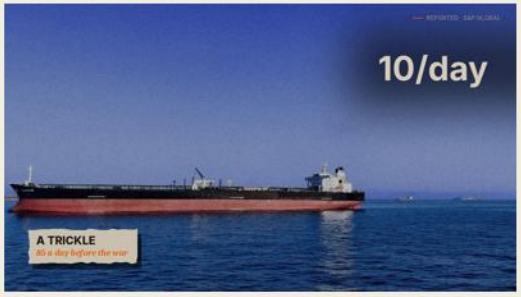
Ship store room / water bottles and food crates on board (still, slow push) + W three draining tiles WATER/FOOD/FUEL



And the door kept almost opening. A ceasefire in April. A memorandum in June. Each time, the strait closed again. The truce collapsed on the eighth of July.

GRAPHIC **P1-08**

T three typed date cards (8 APR / 17 JUN / 8 JUL), each stamped COLLAPSED



Even when ships did move, it was a trickle. On one day in late July, ten vessels crossed. The day before, sixteen. Before the war, the average was eighty-five.

PHOTO **P1-08b** COLOUR · CALM

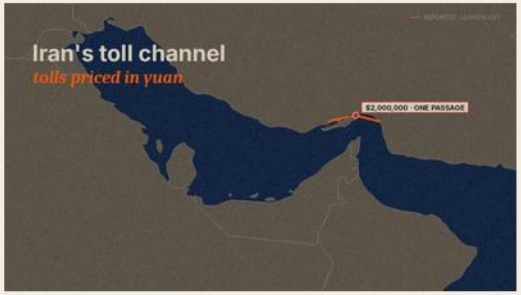
Tankers waiting (still) + corner '10 a day'



And the US Navy has its own blockade of Iran's ports. In early November 2026, it disabled a commercial ship it said was trying to break through. So the water is dangerous from more than one direction.

VIDEO **P1-08c** COLOUR · INTENSE

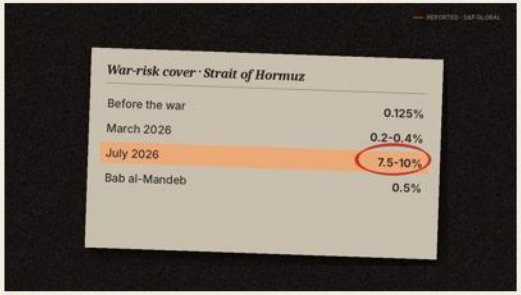
Navy warship at sea, distant (toned) + L 'US BLOCKADE OF IRAN'S PORTS'



Iran set up its own authority to decide who passes. One ship reportedly paid two million dollars to use Iran's northern channel. The tolls, Lloyd's List reported, were priced in Chinese yuan.

GRAPHIC **P1-09**

M strait map, northern channel glows; T paper ticket '$2,000,000 · ONE PASSAGE' with stamp REPORTED



Here is the first line on your bill. Before the war, insuring a ship for one trip through Hormuz cost a fraction of one percent of its value. By July 2026, war cover was seven and a half to ten percent.

GRAPHIC **P1-10**

D insurance rate sheet under magnifier, highlight '7.5-10%'



On one tanker carrying two hundred and seventy thousand tonnes of crude to China, that came to about twenty-one million dollars. Four times the five-year average.

PHOTO **P1-11** **COLOUR · INTENSE**

Huge tanker hull close-up, still with slow pan + N '$21,000,000 · one cargo'



Compare that with the rest of the region. At the same time, crossing Bab al-Mandeb, at the mouth of the Red Sea, cost about half a percent. Off western Saudi Arabia, a tenth of a percent. Hormuz was in a class of its own.

GRAPHIC **P1-11b**

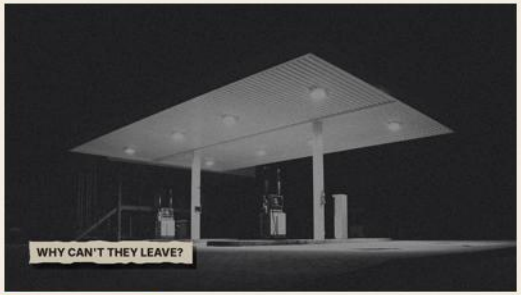
W three tiles: RED SEA 0.1% · BAB AL-MANDEB 0.5% · HORMUZ 10% (glowing)



Spread over about two million barrels, that's roughly ten dollars sixty a barrel. A ten-dollar barrel adds about twenty-four cents to a gallon of petrol. So if all of it were passed on, about twenty-five cents a gallon. In Britain, about six pence a litre.

GRAPHIC **P1-12**

R receipt prints line 1: WAR INSURANCE +25¢/gal · +6p/L, stamp ESTIMATE



That's the upper end. Gulf crude is only part of what goes into your tank. But it's a real cost, and someone pays it. And none of it reaches the people on those ships. So why can't the crews simply leave?

VIDEO **P1-13** **SHADOW**

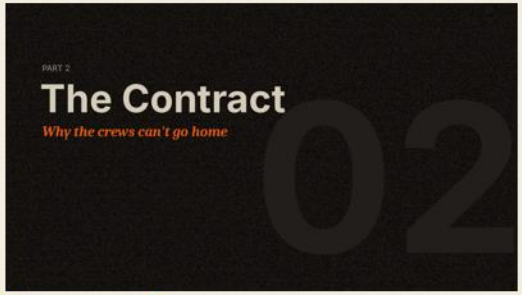
Petrol pump numbers ticking (toned) + L 'WHY CAN'T THEY LEAVE?'



If you want the bill before it arrives, subscribe. Our next video follows this same strait into fertiliser, and into the price of your food.

GRAPHIC **BR-01**

Bridge card with next-video thumbnail (THE HUNGER BILL)



Part two. The contract.

GRAPHIC **P2-01**

P part card 02 'The Contract'



About one point nine million people work on the world's merchant ships. Between them, they move roughly ninety percent of everything traded on Earth. And almost nobody ashore knows their names.

VIDEO **P2-02** COLOUR · CALM

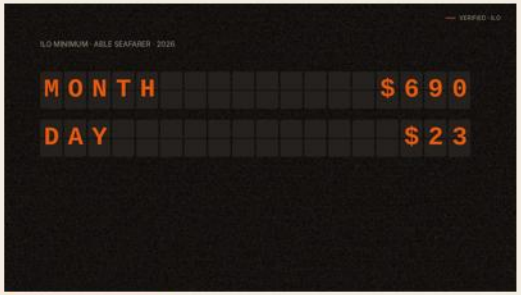
Container ship at sea from above, crew small on deck (no faces) + L '1.9M SEAFARERS · 90% OF TRADE'



Most come from a handful of countries. The Philippines, Russia, Indonesia, China and India. About a quarter of the world's seafarers are Filipino, and about half a million deploy every year.

GRAPHIC **P2-03**

M globe: Philippines, Russia, Indonesia, China, India pinned; Philippines glows; K cut-paper crowd of faceless figures, 1 in 4 orange



The floor for their pay is set at the UN's labour agency. In 2026, the minimum basic wage for an able seafarer is six hundred and ninety dollars a month. About twenty-three dollars a day.

GRAPHIC **P2-04**

N '$690 a month' → B split-flap '$23 / DAY'



A normal contract runs a few months. The international limit for a single stint at sea is eleven months. After that, a sailor has the right to go home. In a closed strait, that right exists on paper.

PHOTO **P2-04b** COLOUR · CALM

Wall calendar in a ship cabin, pages, slow push + label '11-MONTH LIMIT'



So a single trip can carry a twenty-one-million-dollar insurance bill, on a ship crewed by people whose legal minimum is twenty-three dollars a day.

GRAPHIC **P2-05**

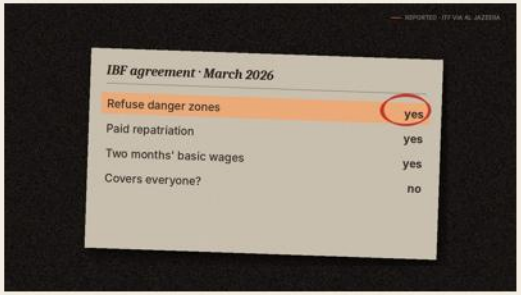
T two paper slips: '$21,000,000' vs '$23', stamp on each



Why don't they walk off? Because a ship can't be left empty. If a crew leaves, someone has to replace them. That means flying new people into a war zone and getting a boat out to the ship. In a war, every one of those steps is dangerous.

VIDEO **P2-06** COLOUR · CALM

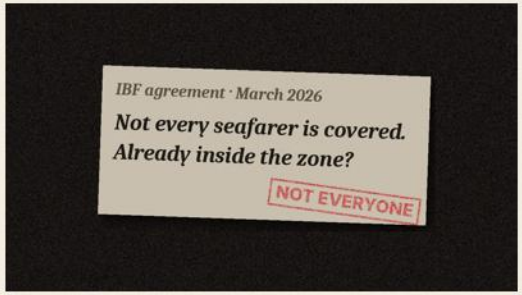
Small launch boat heading out to a distant tanker (toned)



In March 2026, unions and shipping companies agreed new rules. Seafarers can refuse to sail into designated danger zones. Companies must pay to send them home, plus two months' basic wages. The transport workers' federation says pay went up, and compensation for death or injury doubled.

GRAPHIC **P2-07**

D contract page under magnifier: three clauses highlight in turn



It sounds like a way out. But not every seafarer is covered. And the right to refuse doesn't help much if your ship is already inside the zone, waiting.

GRAPHIC **P2-08**

Same contract; red stamp 'NOT EVERYONE'



The law of the sea says no country may suspend passage through a strait like Hormuz. That's Article thirty-eight of the UN Convention. But as one maritime law academic told Al Jazeera, its enforcement is the weak link.

PHOTO **P2-09** COLOUR

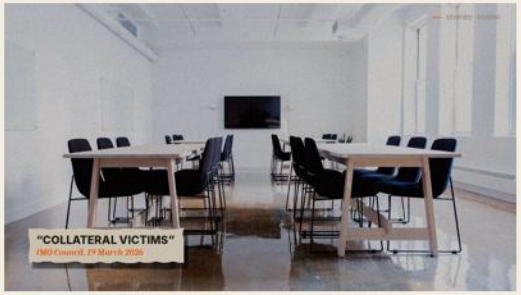
Old law book / UN convention text page, slow pan + T quote card 'its enforcement is the weak link'



The IMO tried. In March 2026, its council met in London and moved to talk about a humanitarian corridor. Iran called the draft one-sided, unfair, inaccurate and legally deficient. China called it one-sided and not balanced.

GRAPHIC **P2-10**

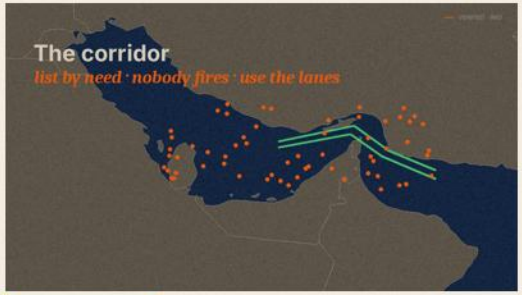
T two typed quote cards (Iran · China), stamp 'IMO COUNCIL · MAR 2026'



Its Secretary-General put it plainly. Seafarers and shipping must never be used as collateral victims of any geopolitical conflict.

VIDEO **P2-10b** COLOUR · INTENSE

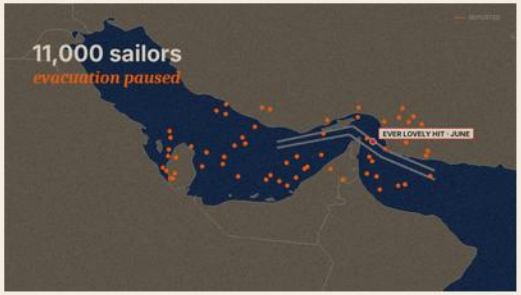
IMO-style conference hall, empty seats (toned) + L quote 'collateral victims'



The plan was simple on paper. List the ships by humanitarian need. Agree that nobody fires. Use the strait's own shipping lanes as the way out. It needed every side to say yes.

GRAPHIC **P2-11**

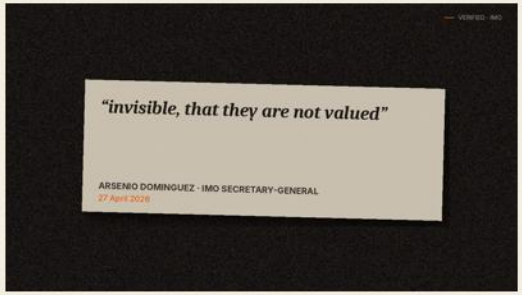
M strait map, lanes glow green as an escape route, ship pins queue



In June, the IMO was ready to move eleven thousand sailors. Then a ship called the Ever Lovely was hit, and the evacuation was paused.

GRAPHIC **P2-12**

Same map, green lane flickers to grey; stamp PAUSED



The IMO's Secretary-General, Arsenio Dominguez, spoke to one seafarer who had been trapped for more than six weeks. He said the crews feel invisible, that they are not valued.

GRAPHIC **P2-13**

T quote card 'invisible, that they are not valued' (no matching photo found)



His call was blunt: release the seafarers, because they are not at fault. Twenty-three dollars a day, no way off, and a corridor that never opened. So how many have paid with more than their time?

GRAPHIC **P2-14**

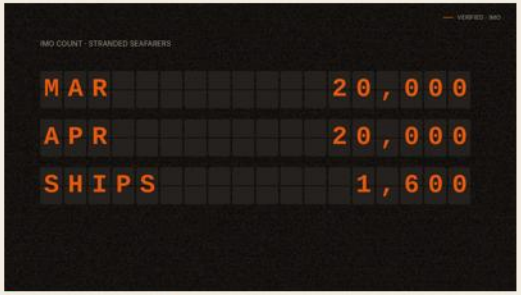
M strait map, ship dots, one pulses (no matching photo found)



Part three. The count.

GRAPHIC **P3-01**

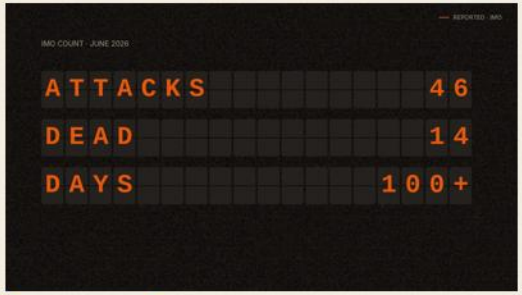
P part card 03 'The Count'



In March 2026, the IMO said about twenty thousand seafarers were stranded in the Gulf. By late April, it was still twenty thousand, now on about sixteen hundred ships.

GRAPHIC **P3-02**

B split-flap tally: MAR 20,000 · APR 20,000 · SHIPS 1,600



By June, the IMO counted forty-six attacks on ships and fourteen seafarers dead. Some ships had been stuck for more than a hundred days.

GRAPHIC **P3-03**

B tally adds JUN: ATTACKS 46 · DEAD 14 · DAYS 100+



By mid-September, twenty-two dead. By the IMO's council meeting in early November, at least twenty-five.

GRAPHIC **P3-04**

W tile line chart 10 → 14 → 22 → 25



More than a hundred and thirty attacks on merchant ships since the war began. October 2026 was the worst month yet. At least thirty-one vessels hit.

GRAPHIC **P3-05**

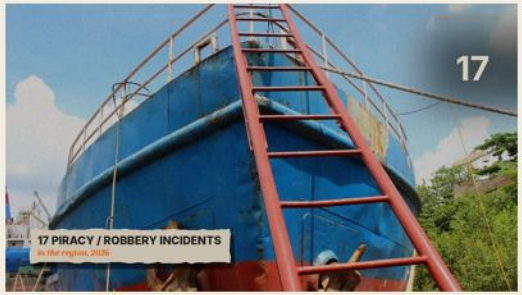
T calendar grid Mar-Nov on paper, October circled red '31'



In one incident, five oil tankers and a tugboat caught fire in separate attacks inside the strait. In October, a tanker called On Peace was struck near Oman. Twelve crew were injured. Eleven of them were Indian.

GRAPHIC **P3-05b**

M strait map: six small fire icons; paper pin 'ON PEACE · 12 INJURED'



And it isn't only missiles and mines. The IMO also counted seventeen piracy and armed robbery incidents in the region in 2026. When navies are busy, criminals notice.

PHOTO **P3-05c** COLOUR · INTENSE

Boarding ladder on a ship's side, still, slow pan + N '17'



India has lost the most. At least sixteen Indian seafarers killed. India is now the world's second-largest supplier of sailors.

PHOTO **P3-06** COLOUR · INTENSE

Indian port still + corner '16' + label 'India · at least 16 killed'



One of them was Gandhar Nahim Ajij, from Gujarat. His cargo ship, the Al Jusufi, was struck off Oman. Thirteen of his crewmates were rescued. He was not.

PHOTO **P3-07** SHADOW

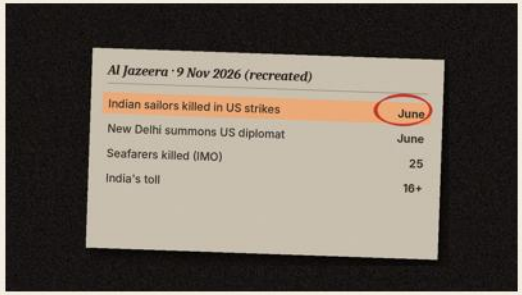
Wooden cargo dhow on calm water at dawn, empty deck (no person)



In September, two Filipino crew died when the Saudi tanker Sidr was hit near the strait. The Philippines then banned its seafarers from the region's high-risk zones.

GRAPHIC **P3-08**

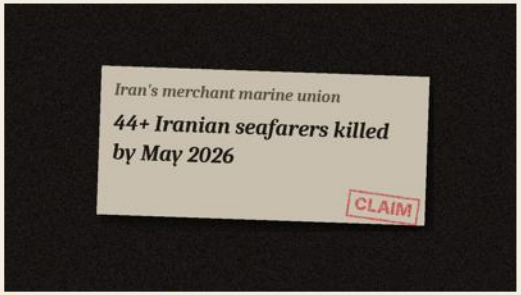
M Philippines glows; T paper notice stamped 'DEPLOYMENT BAN'



Not every death comes from one side. In June, three Indian sailors were killed in US strikes on commercial vessels near Oman. New Delhi summoned a senior American diplomat.

GRAPHIC **P3-09**

D recreated news page (credit Al Jazeera) under magnifier, headline highlighted



And Iran's merchant marine union says at least forty-four Iranian seafarers had been killed by May. That's their claim. It isn't in the IMO's count.

GRAPHIC **P3-10**

T typed card '44+ IRANIAN SEAFARERS · MAY 2026', stamp CLAIM



The waiting has its own cost. The Mission to Seafarers tracks how crews feel. Its wellbeing score has fallen three times in a row. Before this war, the UN labour agency counted twenty-six suicides among four hundred and forty-nine seafarer deaths in 2024.

VIDEO **P3-11** SHADOW

Ship at sea at night, cabin lights on, very slow (toned) + small W tile 7.18 → 6.81



Then there are the ships nobody claims. In late 2026, about eight vessels sat abandoned off the coast of the Emirates. The charity was helping crews on eight to ten ships.

VIDEO **P3-12** SHADOW

Rusty old cargo ship at anchor (toned) + L '8 SHIPS ABANDONED'



Abandonment was already at a record before the war. In 2025, the transport workers' federation logged four hundred and ten abandoned ships. Six thousand two hundred and twenty-three seafarers left without pay or food. Twenty-five point eight million dollars in wages owed.

PHOTO **P3-13** SHADOW

Rusty abandoned ship still + corner '410' + label '6,223 crew · $25.8M unpaid'



So here's the bill so far. On the money side, up to twenty-five cents a gallon in war insurance. On the human side, at least twenty-five lives by the IMO's count. Thousands of crews who can't go home. And families waiting on their pay.

GRAPHIC **P3-14**

R half-receipt: lines 1-3 print, subtotal, stamp 'THE BILL SO FAR'



Has the world been here before? Yes. And the last time, it took a superpower's navy to get the tankers moving.

GRAPHIC **P3-15**

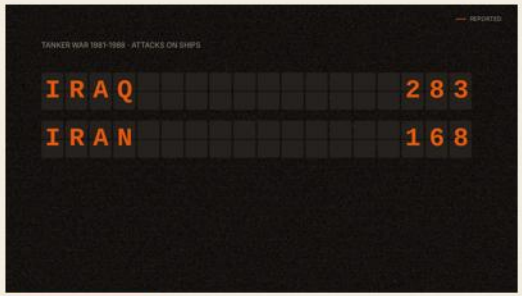
Torn-paper wipe; M map warms to 1980s sepia



Part four. The last time.

GRAPHIC **P4-01**

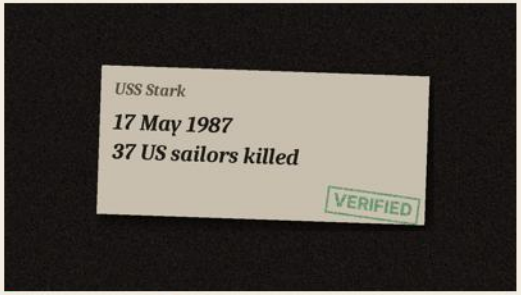
P part card 04 'The Last Time'



From 1981 to 1988, Iran and Iraq fought a war at sea inside their war on land. It's known as the Tanker War. Iraq attacked ships two hundred and eighty-three times. Iran, one hundred and sixty-eight.

GRAPHIC **P4-02**

B split-flap 'IRAQ 283 · IRAN 168' on 1981-1988 header



Well over a hundred sailors were killed. In May 1987, an Iraqi aircraft hit the American frigate USS Stark. Thirty-seven US sailors died.

GRAPHIC **P4-03**

T typed card 'USS STARK · 17 MAY 1987 · 37 KILLED' (public-domain US Navy photo to be added if found)



That year, Washington agreed to put American flags on Kuwaiti tankers and escort them through the Gulf. Operation Earnest Will ran from July 1987 to September 1988.

GRAPHIC **P4-04**

M convoy line Kuwait → Hormuz, flag pins on tankers



The lesson? Escorts can move oil. They don't make the water safe for everyone. And in November 2026, the pattern is back. A Saudi tanker company says it is crossing Hormuz in coordination with the US military.

GRAPHIC **P4-05**

M map: 1987 convoy line + 2026 escorted lane



The second precedent is closer. In 2020, Covid shut the borders that sailors fly through. About four hundred thousand seafarers were stuck aboard, past the end of their contracts. Another four hundred thousand couldn't get to work.

VIDEO **P4-06** **SHADOW**

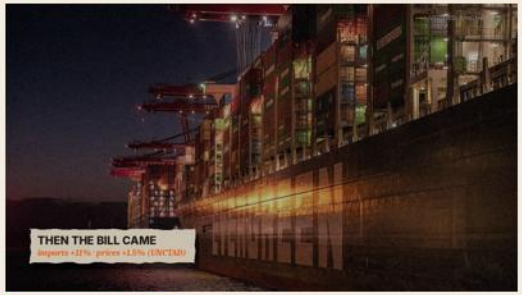
Empty airport departure hall (toned) + N '400,000 STUCK'



The legal limit for a stint at sea is eleven months. Some crews passed seventeen. The head of the IMO warned that overly fatigued and mentally exhausted seafarers were being asked to keep operating ships.

GRAPHIC **P4-07**

T calendar pages flip 1-17, red line at 11; quote card Kitack Lim



Then the bill came. The UN's trade body worked out that if freight stayed that expensive, global import prices would rise eleven percent by 2023, and consumer prices one and a half. Electronics, furniture and clothes, ten percent or more.

VIDEO **P4-08** **COLOUR · CALM**

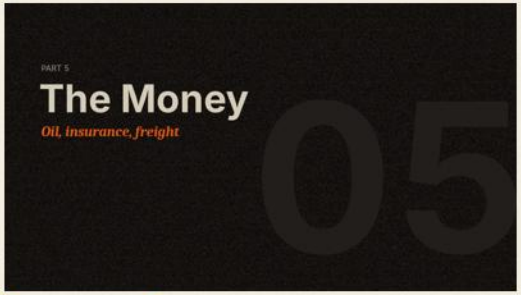
Container port cranes loading (toned) + W tiles +11% / +1.5% / +10%



Shipping costs jumped in 2026 too. So how much of that reaches you this time?

PHOTO **P4-09** COLOUR · CALM

Container port still + label 'And in 2026?'



Part five. The money.

GRAPHIC **P5-01**

P part card 05 'The Money'



Start with oil. Brent crude passed a hundred dollars a barrel on the eighth of March 2026, for the first time in four years. It peaked at a hundred and twenty-six. Dubai crude hit a record one hundred and sixty-six.

VIDEO **P5-02** COLOUR · INTENSE

Oil refinery flare at dusk (toned) + B split-flap BRENT $126 · DUBAI $166



Governments opened their emergency tanks. On the eleventh of March, members of the International Energy Agency released four hundred million barrels.

VIDEO **P5-03** COLOUR · CALM

Oil storage tanks (toned) + N '400M barrels'



By the tenth of November, Brent was around eighty-nine dollars, the lowest since late August, on hopes of a deal. Still about thirty-seven percent higher than a year earlier.

PHOTO **P5-04** COLOUR

Refinery at night (still) + corner '$89' (Brent, 10 Nov 2026)



And here's the honest problem with the headlines. One data service says Middle East oil shipments are close to pre-war levels. The IMO's satellite count found one ship crossing Hormuz on the first of November. Both can be true. Escorted tankers move. Everyone else waits.

GRAPHIC **P5-05**

T two typed cards 'CLOSE TO PRE-WAR' vs '1 SHIP · 1 NOV'; stamp REPORTED on both; M one escorted lane



Now the boxes. Your TV, your trainers, your kettle. By Lloyd's List's numbers, container freight from Shanghai roughly doubled from late February. To the US West Coast, up a hundred and twenty-nine percent. To Northern Europe, up seventy-four.

VIDEO **P5-06** COLOUR · INTENSE

Container ship at port (generic, no brand visible) + B '+129% US · +74% EUROPE'



Ships burn more fuel when they wait and reroute. Bunker fuel rose sixty-eight percent. Lloyd's List reported Maersk paying about five hundred million dollars a month extra for fuel. Hapag-Lloyd, fifty to sixty million euros a week.

VIDEO **P5-07** COLOUR · INTENSE

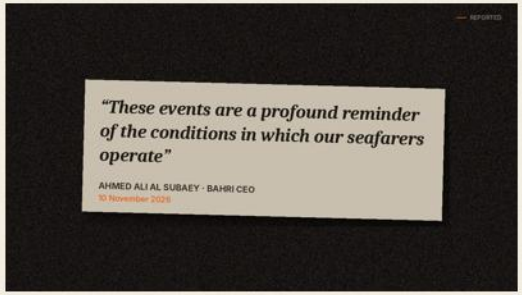
Ship engine room / fuel bunkering hose (toned) + N '+68% fuel'



Who wins? Some shipowners. Saudi tanker company Bahri reported third-quarter profit about ten times higher than a year earlier. In the same quarter, it lost two crew members to attacks.

GRAPHIC **P5-08**

K cut-paper executives (faceless) with paper tags 'BAHRI Q3 · PROFIT ×10' and '2 CREW KILLED'



Its chief executive said these events are a profound reminder of the conditions in which their seafarers operate.

GRAPHIC **P5-09**

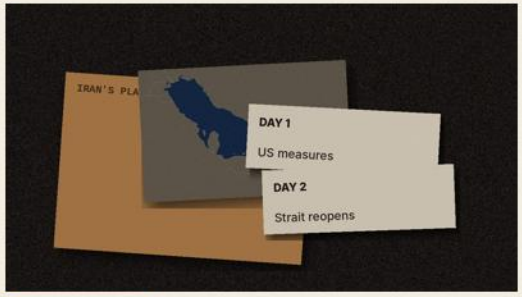
T typed quote card, Bahri CEO, 10 Nov 2026



There is one more way out, and it runs through Washington. In November 2026, Qatar's prime minister met President Trump at the White House. Iran had sent a new proposal through Qatar.

PHOTO **P5-09b** COLOUR · CALM

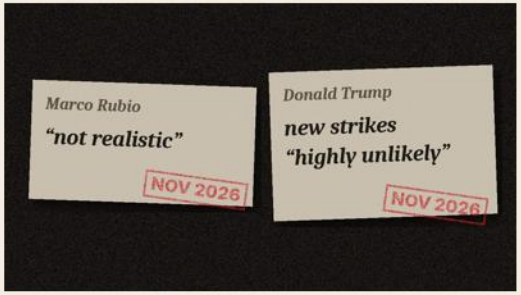
White House exterior (generic public still), slow push



Iran's foreign minister described it as two days. On day one, the US carries out a set of measures. On day two, the Strait of Hormuz reopens. Iran's demands include sanctions relief, a smaller US military presence, its frozen money back, and recognition of its own shipping route.

GRAPHIC **P5-09c**

X folder: DAY 1 / DAY 2 index cards; demands list ticks in



America's top diplomat, Marco Rubio, called some of those demands outrageous and ridiculous, and really not realistic. President Trump said new strikes were highly unlikely if the talks produce a strong agreement. Three American aircraft carriers are in the region. Iran's Revolutionary Guard says its forces are at the ready.

GRAPHIC **P5-09d**

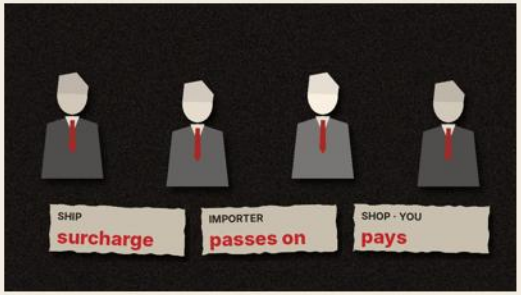
T two quote cards (Rubio · Trump); M map with 3 carrier pins



So the strait is a bargaining chip. And the crews are inside the chip. Every week of talks is another week at anchor for thousands of people who aren't at the table.

VIDEO **P5-09e** **SHADOW**

Ships waiting at anchor at dusk, still water (toned) + L 'THE CREWS AREN'T AT THE TABLE'



So who pays? Shipping lines pass fuel and insurance on as surcharges. Importers pass them to shops. Shops pass them to you. It takes months, and it's never one for one.

GRAPHIC **P5-10**

K cut-paper chain: ship → importer → shop → wallet, paper coins slide along



Using that 2021 UN estimate as a guide, and scaling it to the smaller freight jump of 2026, our rough estimate is half a percent to just over one percent on imported goods. Five to twelve dollars on every thousand a family spends.

GRAPHIC **P5-11**

R receipt line 2: FREIGHT ON GOODS +$5-12 per $1,000, stamp ESTIMATE



So what is on your receipt, line by line? And what can you actually do about it?

GRAPHIC **P5-12**

Hold on R receipt



Part six. Your table.

GRAPHIC **P6-01**

P part card 06 'Your Table'



In America, if every cent of that war insurance reached the pump, it would be up to about twenty-five cents a gallon. On a fifteen-gallon tank, about three dollars eighty.

VIDEO **P6-02** COLOUR · INTENSE

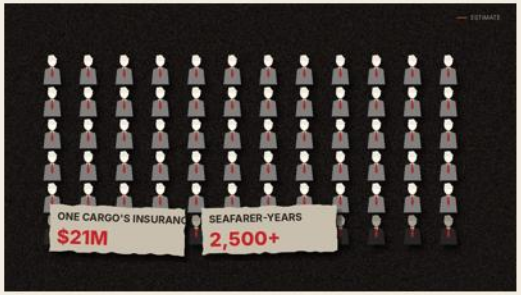
US petrol pump nozzle into a car (generic) + N '+$3.80 a tank'



In fact, American petrol has been getting cheaper. The national average fell below four dollars a gallon in November 2026. So this is a cost hiding inside a falling price, not a new spike.

VIDEO **P6-03** COLOUR · CALM

Pump nozzle into a car (toned) + corner '<$4' + label 'a cost hiding inside a falling price'



Here's a way to picture it. The war insurance on one tanker, about twenty-one million dollars, would pay the legal minimum wage of more than two and a half thousand seafarers for a year.

GRAPHIC **P6-03b**

K paper grid of 2,536 small figures filling in vs one paper tanker '$21M'



In Britain, up to about six pence a litre, with VAT. Roughly three pounds thirty on a fifty-five-litre tank. Again, that's the upper end.

GRAPHIC **P6-04**

N '+£3.30 a tank' (UK, 55 L, with VAT)



On the shelf, five to twelve dollars, or pounds, on every thousand you spend in a month. Mostly on imported things. Electronics, furniture, clothes.

GRAPHIC **P6-05**

W tiles: electronics / furniture / clothes, +5-12 per 1,000



In South Asia and the Philippines, the bill looks different. It isn't the price of the cargo. It's the pay packet. Filipino seafarers sent home seven point one billion dollars in 2025. About a fifth of all the money Filipinos abroad sent to their families.

GRAPHIC **P6-06**

M globe: Philippines glows, money arcs home, '$7.1B (2025)'



That's about six hundred million dollars a month that depends on crews being allowed to work, and allowed to come home. A ban on danger zones protects lives. It also cuts that line.

GRAPHIC **P6-07**

M Philippines; money arc from the Gulf; a gate closes; N '≈$600M a month'



India is the same story at a different scale. It is now the world's second-largest supplier of seafarers, and it has set itself a target to grow that share.

PHOTO **P6-07b** COLOUR · CALM

Mumbai port / Indian harbour still, slow pan



India has lost more seafarers in this war than any other country. Behind each of those sixteen is a household that lost a person, and a wage.

VIDEO **P6-08** SHADOW

Harbour at dusk, small boats, no faces (toned)



And one line never shows up at the till. Every time a strait closes, companies hold more stock, ship slower and pay more for safety. That habit, and its cost, doesn't end the day the guns stop.

VIDEO **P6-09** SHADOW

Warehouse aisles full of stock (toned) + L 'THE COST OF NOT TRUSTING THE SEA'



So here's the full receipt.

GRAPHIC **P6-10**

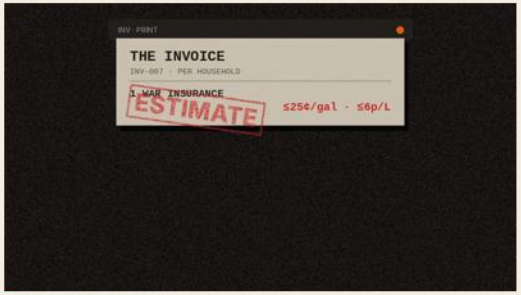
R receipt slides to centre



The receipt.

GRAPHIC **RC-01**

P part card 'The Receipt'



Line one. War insurance on Gulf crude. Up to twenty-five cents a gallon, or about six pence a litre. An estimate, at the upper end.

GRAPHIC **RC-02**

R line 1, stamp ESTIMATE



Line two. Freight on imported goods. Five to twelve for every thousand of monthly spending. An estimate.

GRAPHIC **RC-03**

R line 2, stamp ESTIMATE



Line three. Lives. At least twenty-five seafarers by the IMO's count, as of November 2026. Iran's union claims more.

GRAPHIC **RC-04**

R line 3 in crimson, stamp VERIFIED



Line four. Time. Thousands of crews held at sea. About six thousand, on up to four hundred ships, by one late-October count.

PHOTO **RC-05** COLOUR · CALM

Ships at anchor wide still, slow push + R line 4 overlaid



Line five. Pay. Twenty-three dollars a day, at the legal minimum, for the people carrying the cargo.

GRAPHIC **RC-06**

R line 5; total 'NOT PAID BY YOU ALONE', stamp PAID/UNPAID pair as in reference



What can you do? This is not financial advice. But a few things are always sensible. Keep a buffer of three to six months of essential bills. Test your budget with fuel and food twenty percent higher.

GRAPHIC **RC-07**

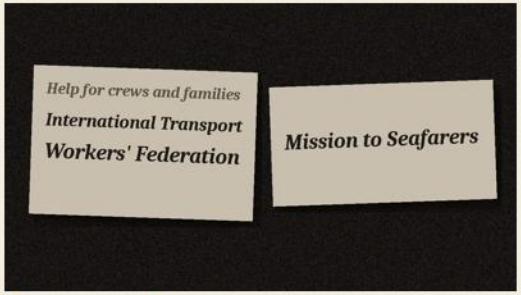
X folder + index cards: 1 · 3-6 months of essentials, 2 · +20% stress test



Don't trade on headlines. Oil fell fast on talk of a deal in November 2026, and it can rise just as fast. And when you read that a strait has reopened, ask who actually got out.

GRAPHIC **RC-08**

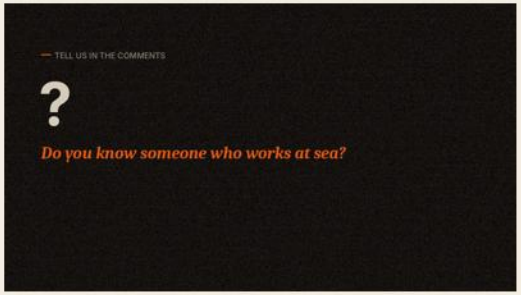
X index cards: 3 · don't trade headlines, 4 · ask who got out



If you have family at sea, the International Transport Workers' Federation and the Mission to Seafarers both help crews and their families.

GRAPHIC **RC-09**

T typed card: help for crews · ITF · Mission to Seafarers



Tell us in the comments. Do you know someone who works at sea? Or what did your last fill-up cost? Country and number.

GRAPHIC **RC-10**

Comment card + end screen to The Hunger Bill



The cargo of the Velos Sapphire will reach someone's tank, eventually. One of her crew will never reach home.

PHOTO **RC-11** **SHADOW**

Return to the CO-01 tanker still at night; fade to black; then E particle logo 'THE HISTORY INVOICE'